

I don't inherently dislike war movies.

Henry Metz

My family loves them—there’s something about learning through entertainment that appeals to them. I’ve watched many of the so-called classics. And while each has its distinguishing features, I often walk away feeling the same. Most war films boil down to “look how horrible war is.” Usually, this message comes through by placing the viewer alongside soldiers on the ground, asking us to empathize.

To be clear, I do empathize. But at the risk of sounding cold, I’ve rarely felt the need to rewatch one. *Schindler’s List*, *All Quiet on the Western Front*, *1917*, *Dunkirk*—I saw all of them, appreciated each on its own terms, and moved on.

Spielberg’s film is a compelling depiction of moral resistance during the Holocaust. *All Quiet* offers a rare German WWI perspective and handles it well. *1917* earns admiration through its one-shot illusion and striking cinematography. As for *Dunkirk*, I’ll admit I was too young to grasp the triple timeline structure on first watch, but I’ve come to admire Nolan’s experimental storytelling. These films are skillfully made. But they never left a deep personal impression on me.

So when I read the synopsis for *The Zone of Interest*, I was hesitant. The premise sounded unique enough that I expected to take something new from it, as I had with the others. But I didn’t expect to love it.

Then the film started.

Unlike any other war film, it begins not with a dramatic image or a sweeping orchestral cue, but total blackness. Studio cards play. Then the title fades in and out. The screen stays black. And for three full minutes, nothing visual happens.

Instead, the sound design immediately takes hold. Ominous, pulsing music builds like a physical sickness. It made me feel queasy—genuinely uneasy. Low tones are layered with

whispering voices, then chirping birds. The effect is suffocating. When the music finally fades out, the first image appears: a still, wide shot of people picnicking by a river. We don't know who they are. The camera doesn't move. No one explains anything, and nothing visually changes for another full minute.

This is how Jonathan Glazer opens his film. Not with exposition, not with a protagonist, not even with light. But with sound. With dread. With the absence of clarity.

I could recap this film scene by scene and never get bored. But what makes *The Zone of Interest* the most effective, poignant, and unique depiction of war I've ever seen is not its plot. It's Glazer's fly-on-the-wall directorial style and his meticulous, often brutal use of sound. These are the two aspects I will focus on.

Sound is not an accessory in *The Zone of Interest*. It is the movie's moral center. It does not complement the action—it replaces it. There is almost no traditional score. Dialogue is sparse. But in the background, always, is the mechanical hum of genocide.

Train whistles. Muffled screaming. Gunshots. Shoveling. Dogs barking. A furnace roaring. These are not shown onscreen. They are heard, clearly and consistently, behind the scenes of otherwise ordinary conversations. Hedwig Höss plays with her children. She hosts friends for tea. She admires her garden. Behind her laughter, behind the chatter, you hear death.

One of the most disturbing uses of sound comes in a garden scene. Prisoners spread ash into the soil as fertilizer. You hear the gentle rustle of the soil. You hear birds. You hear a faint engine. Then a child's voice. Somewhere beyond the wall, a human is being killed, and the film does not cut away or dramatize it. It stays with the garden.

The audience is forced to live with this sound the way the Höss family does. Not through spectacle or violence, but as background noise. There's no catharsis. Just quiet horror.

Mica Levi's music adds to this. It's used sparingly. When it comes in, it hits like a panic attack. Screeching. Wailing. Whispering. It feels like a spirit trapped beneath the floorboards, trying to claw its way out. In several night scenes, Levi's score combines with thermal camera footage showing a girl sneaking through the darkness to leave apples. These are the only sequences in the film that show resistance or compassion. And they're also the only ones that feel surreal, almost ghostly. The music makes them feel like brief flashes of a buried conscience.

The rest of the film avoids such expression entirely.

Glazer doesn't want to guide you emotionally. He avoids close-ups. He avoids lighting setups. He doesn't let you feel "in" the scene. Instead, he uses multiple hidden cameras—often as many as ten at once—and captures the actors from afar. The style feels like surveillance footage. The characters don't perform for the camera. They're observed. The effect is chilling.

When you watch this film, you feel like you're spying. But no one seems to care. The characters carry on. The horrors remain out of frame. The implication is clear: this isn't a story about discovering evil. It's about how easily people live next to it.

This fly-on-the-wall approach strips the film of traditional emotional cues. There is no protagonist. There are no hero moments. There is no release. By shooting everything in long, static takes and using only natural light, Glazer creates a world that feels uncomfortably real—more like watching security footage than cinema. That choice isn't a gimmick. It's the entire point.

This is a film about looking away.

Glazer's formal instincts in *The Zone of Interest* don't emerge from nowhere. Previous short films of his, *The Fall* and *Strasbourg 1518*, reveal the same obsession with control, silence, and moral unease.

In *The Fall*, a man is hunted, hanged, and dropped into a well by a masked mob. The short plays out with no dialogue and no exposition. The masks hide expression. The rope creaks. A mechanical hum dominates the soundscape. The film ends with no resolution—just a man crawling upward, his fate unknown. It’s a nightmare rendered with minimalist precision. Everything unnecessary is stripped away. What remains is dread. Mica Levi’s score here is subtle but tense, fusing sound with image the same way it does in *The Zone of Interest*: not to guide emotion, but to trap it.

Strasbourg 1518, made during the COVID lockdown, shifts focus from violence to physical compulsion. Dancers perform alone in bare rooms, writhing and twisting to an unrelenting industrial beat. There is no narrative. There is no context. But there is structure—tight framing, harsh light, and rhythmic cuts that echo emotional panic. The score—again by Levi—doesn’t accompany the movement; it drives it. Each body moves like it’s trying to escape something invisible. That same energy pulses through *The Zone of Interest*, especially in the sequences where the camera stays locked on the mundane while chaos unfolds just out of frame.

Both shorts reflect the same strategy Glazer uses in *The Zone of Interest*: visual restraint paired with sonic intensity. The horror is never shown. It is heard. It is implied. And it is made worse by how ordinary everything around it seems. By the time Glazer arrives at Auschwitz, he doesn’t need to show it. He’s already taught us how to feel it.

Critics have mostly responded to *The Zone of Interest* with respect—some with awe, others with skepticism.

Wendy Ide of *The Guardian* calls it a “brutal masterpiece,” praising both the sound design by Johnnie Burn and the chilling score by Mica Levi. She singles out the film’s sonic

textures—the oppressive background noise, the screams, the low industrial hum—as central to its emotional weight. Ide compares the film’s emotional effect to “a lightning bolt,” saying it “stayed with [her], stubbornly.” For her, the restraint and formal control make the film more devastating, not less.

The New Yorker’s Anthony Lane also recognizes Glazer’s precision. He focuses on what the film withholds. There are no graphic images of violence, and yet you hear it. Lane suggests this absence doesn’t soften the horror—it sharpens it. He admires Glazer’s “tenacity ... technical skill, and ... tact,” noting how the fly-on-the-wall distance prevents viewers from looking away. He also highlights a key moment: Hedwig Höss trying on a coat stolen from a murdered prisoner. The scene is not dramatized. It’s observed. And that’s what makes it horrifying.

But not every critic agrees. Manohla Dargis of *The New York Times* calls the film “hollow” and “self-aggrandizing.” She acknowledges the ambition and the stylistic precision, but questions whether the film risks turning atrocity into aesthetic. Dargis argues that the focus on the perpetrators—their quiet routines, their moral detachment—ultimately overshadows the victims, reducing suffering to “room tone.” Her critique is not about facts or technical execution. It’s about emotional distance. For her, the film may be too controlled for its own good.

Whether one agrees with Dargis or not, her point adds necessary tension to the conversation. *The Zone of Interest* has been showered with praise, including multiple Oscar nominations—Best Picture, Best Director, and Best Adapted Screenplay—and two wins: Best International Feature and, I believe most importantly, Best Sound. But its effectiveness doesn’t lie in universal appeal. It lies in how much discomfort it’s willing to let us sit with.

Glazer doesn’t offer easy answers. He doesn’t offer any. And that’s why, for me, the film stands apart.

The Zone of Interest doesn't follow the traditional structure of a war movie. It doesn't necessarily aim to educate or to entertain. It doesn't even try to tell a story in the usual sense. Instead, it traps you beside evil. It forces you to hear what you don't see, to notice what the characters ignore. Through its stripped-back style and relentless use of sound, it becomes a portrait not of violence, but of how violence becomes invisible.

I've seen dozens of war films. This is the first one that felt like a warning.

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